There was one precious resource here that traders and rulers coming to Maski would have dearly sought: gold. The region was rich in gold deposits. Known to geologists as the main Maski band of the Dharwar series, a number of old gold workings here underline the fact that these deposits were exploited in premodern times. Old workings have been found near Maski, and many in areas not too far beyond. Two gold objects of the first millennium BCE found at the site make it seem most likely that the auriferous veins here were mined in very ancient times.[38] The chance discovery of the Ashokan edict at Maski was in fact the result of the prospecting for gold in 1915 by a gold-mining engineer of the nizam's dominions, C. Beadon, in that area. One may even imagine that Ashoka's provincial capital in this region, known as Survarnagiri ('golden mountain'), may have been so named because of its control and regulation of gold, with Maski as a base for prospecting and mining.

The sense that the reference points of this settlement extended much beyond its immediate environment is reinforced by different kinds of graffiti marks on some of the pottery, from the habitation area as well as from burials. There were some nineteen types of marks, either scratched or incised, including trident-like marks, bows, carelessly incised crosses, V-like incision marks, and one resembling an arrowhead. These form part of a marking system that has left its signature at several places in South India and Sri Lanka. Those who have carefully studied the contexts in which these were found believe this graffiti is a kind of precursor of a writing system, with places like Vallam (near Thanjavur) and Mangudi (south-west of Madurai) yielding sequences where the initial phase reveals only graffiti, followed by one where the graffiti combines with the Brahmi script, and eventually the Brahmi script appearing to the exclusion of earlier forms.[39] In other places, as at Kodumanal near Erode, Brahmi inscriptions on pottery show graffiti marks incised at the end.[40] Either way, graffiti seems to have